

AUTOMATION

STARTER KIT

10 Automations Every SME Should Have Running

ZAPIER

MAKE

N8N

SHOPIFY

A Practical Starter Kit for Time-Poor Business Owners

Who Are Sick of Doing Manually What Software Should Do.



10

10 Recipes Ready to Use

3 Platforms Covered

6-12hrs Saved Per Week

\$0 to Start

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The 10 Hours a Week You're Wasting

And how to get them back.

If you run a small or medium business, there's a solid chance you're doing at least a dozen things every week that a piece of software could handle in zero seconds flat. Not because you're disorganised — but because nobody ever sat you down and showed you the alternative.

8–12 hours per week wasted by the average SME

on fully automatable tasks. That's one working day. Every single week.

The Real Cost of Manual Work

The 10 automations in this kit collectively save the average SME owner 6–12 hours per week. At \$150/hour, that's \$900–\$1,800 in recovered time. Every week.

Website lead comes in

You open your CRM, create a contact, copy name/email/phone. Five minutes. Every. Single. Lead.

Shopify order arrives

You forward it to your warehouse via email or WhatsApp. Two minutes. Per order.

Friday afternoon

Your manager needs the weekly sales report. You open four tabs, pull numbers, paste into a spreadsheet, format it, email it. Forty-five minutes.

Customer buys something

You'll ask for a review. When you remember. Sometimes.

The Automation Mindset

What to automate first — and why order matters.

Not all automation is created equal. Before you start plugging things together, spend five minutes thinking about what to automate and in what order.

The Four Pillars of a Good Automation Target

01 It happens frequently

Do it daily → automate it. Do it twice a year → manual is fine.

02 It follows a consistent pattern

"Every time X happens, do Y" is the sweet spot. Complex judgment calls every time — not ready yet.

03 It's currently causing problems

Dropped leads. Late invoices. Missed follow-ups. If the manual version is failing you, automation is the fix.

04 The stakes of a mistake are high

If forgetting a follow-up costs you a \$5K sale, that task is worth protecting with automation.

The Three Automation Layers (Build in this order)

LAYER	TYPE	DESCRIPTION	BUILD FIRST?
Layer 1	Capture	Ensure nothing falls through the cracks: lead forms, inquiry re...	Yes — start here
Layer 2	Communicatio...	Ensure customers and team hear from you at the right mome...	Second
Layer 3	Intelligence	Aggregate and surface information you'd otherwise dig for: w...	Third

Tool Overview

Zapier vs Make vs n8n — the straight version.

FEATURE	ZAPIER	MAKE	N8N
Pricing (2026)	Free / \$29.99+/mo	Free / \$16+/mo	Free (self-hosted) / \$24+/...
Ease of use	Very easy — built for be...	Moderate — more visual...	Moderate — technical but f...
Best for	First automations, non-t...	Visual workflow builders	Developers or power users
AI agent support	Yes — Zapier Agents (b...	Yes — native AI steps	Yes — extensive AI node li...
Reliability	Excellent	Very good	Good (depends on hosting...
Our recommendation	Start here	Upgrade to this	When you outgrow Make

Which Tool to Use

Our recommendation: Start with Zapier for your first 1–3 automations. Once you're comfortable with the concepts, consider migrating complex workflows to Make for more power and lower cost. Move to n8n only if you have technical resources or want full data ownership.

What about AI Agents?

AI agents are automations that can make decisions, not just follow rules. In 2026, all three platforms support some form of AI agent capability. For most SMEs, start with rule-based automation first — add AI decision-making once the basics are running reliably. Complexity is the enemy of consistency.

RECIPE #1

Lead Capture → CRM Entry

Never lose a lead again

TRIGGER: New form submission (Typeform, website form, or Facebook Lead Ad)

ACTION: Create contact in CRM (HubSpot, Pipedrive, or similar)

OPTIONAL: Send internal Slack/email notification to sales owner

OPTIONAL: Send automated reply email to lead confirming receipt

Impact

Time saved: ~5 min per lead. At 20 leads/week = 1.7 hrs/week recovered.

Implementation Notes

- Zapier: Lead form → HubSpot · Steps: 2 · Build time: 15 min
- Make: Facebook Lead Ads → Pipedrive · Steps: 3 · Build time: 20 min
- Complexity: □□□ Beginner

RECIPE #2

New Order → Fulfilment Notification

Instant team alert on every Shopify sale

TRIGGER: New order in Shopify

ACTION: Send notification to fulfilment team via Slack, email, or WhatsApp

INCLUDE: Customer name, items, shipping address, order notes

OPTIONAL: Update a Google Sheet order log automatically

Impact

Eliminates manual order forwarding. Speeds up pick/pack by 30–60 mins daily.

Implementation Notes

- Platform: Zapier or Make · Shopify trigger is native
- Complexity: □□□ Beginner · Build time: 20 min

RECIPE #3

Weekly Report → Email Delivery

Automated every Friday · Zero manual effort

TRIGGER: Schedule — every Friday at 8am

ACTION: Pull data from Google Sheets, GA4, or Shopify

FORMAT: Build a simple report in email or Google Doc

SEND: Email to founder and/or team leads automatically

Impact

Saves 45–90 min per week. Ensures reporting happens even when you're busy.

Implementation Notes

- Requires: Connected data source (Sheets, Shopify, or GA4)
- Complexity: □□□ Intermediate · Build time: 45 min

RECIPE #4

Customer Review Request

Send at exactly the right moment — automatically

TRIGGER: Order status → "Delivered" in Shopify OR X days after purchase

ACTION: Send email via Klaviyo, Mailchimp, or direct SMTP

MESSAGE: Personalised request linking directly to Google or product review page

FILTER: Exclude customers who have already left a review

Impact

Review volume typically 3–5x for businesses that ask consistently.

Implementation Notes

- Platform: Zapier or Klaviyo native · Complexity: □□□
- Build time: 20 min · Ongoing value: Extremely high

RECIPE #5

Invoice → Payment Reminder Sequence

Get paid faster without awkward follow-up calls

TRIGGER: Invoice created in Xero/QuickBooks with due date

ACTION 1: Send reminder 3 days before due date

ACTION 2: Send reminder on due date (if unpaid)

ACTION 3: Send overdue notice 7 days after due date

Impact

Average reduction in debtor days: 8–12 days. Significant cashflow improvement.

Implementation Notes

- Platform: Xero native OR Zapier + Xero + email
- Complexity: □□□ Intermediate · Build time: 40 min

RECIPE #6

Social Mention → Team Alert

Never miss when someone talks about your brand

TRIGGER: Mention of your brand/product on Twitter/X, Instagram, or Google

SOURCE: Use Brand24, Mention.com, or Google Alerts as trigger source

ACTION: Send to team Slack channel with link and excerpt

FILTER: Score by sentiment — flag negative mentions urgently

Impact

Response time to negative reviews drops from days to hours. Significant reputation protection.

Implementation Notes

- Platform: Zapier + Brand24 OR Make + Google Alerts
- Complexity: □□□ Intermediate · Build time: 30 min

RECIPE #7

New Inquiry → Instant Response + Booking

Be faster than any competitor at responding to leads

TRIGGER: New contact form submission or email inquiry

ACTION: Send automated reply within 60 seconds

INCLUDE: Personal greeting, brief intro, direct Calendly or booking link

NOTIFY: Alert sales owner in Slack simultaneously

Impact

Businesses that respond within 5 minutes are 100x more likely to close than those who respond in 30+ minutes.

Implementation Notes

- Platform: Zapier · Typeform or website form trigger
- Complexity: □□□ Beginner · Build time: 20 min

RECIPE #8

Inventory Low → Supplier Email Alert

Restock before you run out — automatically

TRIGGER: Shopify inventory drops below threshold (e.g. 10 units)

ACTION: Send email to supplier with product SKU, name, and reorder quantity

CC: Purchasing manager or founder

LOG: Record reorder event in Google Sheets

Impact

Eliminates stockouts caused by forgetting to check inventory. Particularly valuable for fast-moving SKUs.

Implementation Notes

- Platform: Zapier + Shopify · Native inventory trigger
- Complexity: □□□ Beginner · Build time: 25 min

RECIPE #9

Monthly P&L → Accountant Delivery

Financials delivered automatically, every month

TRIGGER: Schedule — 1st of every month at 7am

ACTION: Export P&L report from Xero or QuickBooks

SEND: Email to accountant and founder with attached report

OPTIONAL: Add AI summary of key movements month-on-month

Impact

Saves 1–2 hours of manual export and email per month. Ensures your accountant always has current data.

Implementation Notes

- Platform: Xero native OR Zapier + Xero + Gmail
- Complexity: □□□ Intermediate · Build time: 35 min

RECIPE #10

Competitor Price Change → Your Alert

Stay ahead of the market without manual monitoring

TRIGGER: Price change detected on competitor product page

SOURCE: Use Distill.io or similar web monitoring tool

ACTION: Send Slack or email alert with old price, new price, and product link

OPTIONAL: Trigger a pricing review task in your project management tool

Impact

Competitive pricing awareness without manual checking. Typically checks every 6–24 hours automatically.

Implementation Notes

- Platform: Distill.io → Zapier → Slack
- Complexity: □□□ Intermediate · Build time: 45 min

Build Your First Automation

Step-by-step — complete beginners welcome.

1 Step 1: Choose your trigger

Pick one task that happens every day or multiple times per week. Start with Lead Capture → CRM Entry or New Order → Team Notification.

2 Step 2: Create a free Zapier account

Go to zapier.com, sign up for free. You get 100 tasks per month — enough to test and validate before paying anything.

3 Step 3: Click "Create Zap"

Hit the orange "+ Create" button in the top left. You'll see a two-step canvas: Trigger and Action.

4 Step 4: Set your trigger

Search for your trigger app (e.g. "Typeform"). Select the trigger event (e.g. "New Entry"). Connect your account. Test the trigger.

5 Step 5: Set your action

Search for your action app (e.g. "HubSpot"). Select the action (e.g. "Create Contact"). Map fields from trigger → action.

6 Step 6: Turn it on and test

Toggle the Zap to "On". Submit a real test entry. Verify the contact appears in your CRM. Celebrate.

7 Step 7: Monitor for 2 weeks

Check the Zap history daily for the first two weeks. Fix any errors. Once it's running reliably, move on to your second automation.

READY TO GO FURTHER?

Your First 3 Automations Are Waiting.

Book a free discovery call with Ignition Agency. We'll review which of these 10 recipes fits your business best, help you prioritise, and either walk you through building it yourself or build it for you.

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